

The Antikythera Covenant

***By* Elias Petra**

For my wife Laura with whom everything is possible.
For Joy and Mark without whom I wouldn't exist.

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This is a work of historical fiction. It imagines events and conversations around figures known from history and scripture, but it makes no claim to be doctrine, revelation, or an authenticated historical account.

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London, Easter 2014

News from excavations near the Thiksey Monastery in Ladakh has attracted unexpected attention among historians and religious scholars. Of particular interest is one of the finds: a manuscript that appears to be a secular gospel, written not by a Christian or a Jew but by a monk who knew Jesus before he became the Christ, beginning with the years omitted from the canonical Gospels.

What sets Jesus apart from the other great figures of history is how his impact lasted well after he died, his message reinvigorated by Saints Peter, Paul, Augustine, Benedict, and Francis. But... has the man himself become trapped behind the massive façade of the Church created in his name, and its insistence on using the language of the metaphysical?

Could this discovery bridge the sixty or so generations that separate us from classical antiquity and bridge the divide between believers and those who, since the Age of Reason, have found the idea that God could exist so difficult to accept?



Ladakh 36 AD

I am Tenzin, son of a merchant in the mountain kingdom of Ladakh. I have just received news that my friend Joseph from Arimathea, who I met in Petra, has died, and I am the last of those who have come to be known as the "Three Wise Men": Philip, Joseph, and I, who were present at the birth of Jesus the Nazarene, the one they now call "the Christ". Joseph and I were present at his "Sermon on the Mount", where he laid out his beliefs, and Joseph was present when they crucified him for those beliefs, two short years later. It has come time to give testament to the man I knew and all I have seen, some of which I can explain and some of which, even now, I cannot explain, before it is lost to history.

Ladakh is an ancient mountainous land, mentioned by the Greek historian Herodotus, between its more well-known neighbour, Kashmir, and Tibet at the western end of the Himalayas. So beautiful was it that I always imagined I had been born in paradise. And yet something was missing. I always longed for something more, a feeling that there had to be something more than the material world which, through my family's wealth, bore me no real concern. I longed to travel with the camel trains from the mines, taking the gold of Ladakh beyond the world that was known to me.

My wanderlust was not diminished by my contact with the Dropka people of the next valley, whose tales of ancient and exotic lands to the west came to form a kind of obsession. It is the tradition of the Dropka that they were soldiers from the army of Alexander the Great who had taken refuge in the area some three hundred years before, and it was from the Dropka that I learned the language of the Greeks, not knowing how useful it was to be in the journey to come.

In time I came of age, and the chance to join a trading party headed west presented itself despite the reservations of my friends and family. I jumped at the chance. Now was my opportunity to leave the valleys and see the world beyond. As I trekked out of the valley that had formed my life up to that point, I turned to take one last look at the features of the Great Father, the distinctive mountain rising, like a great white tooth, that had been a part of every day of my life. Then I turned and followed my companions into the unknown.

Petra 1 BC

The ancient world was crisscrossed by the lifeblood of all ages: trading routes where the ideas of societies, perhaps thousands of miles apart, met in a great mixing of cultures. My path swung west and, after a journey of two years, filled with adventures that don't enter into this story, passing through the states of India, Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran, and Iraq, brought me to where the trading routes of the east met the empires of the western world at the great trading town of Petra in Jordan.

Nestled in the red rock of a desert valley, Petra is a town that makes quite an impression. Its location is so well hidden that later it was only known to the local Bedouin. Its entrance is through a narrow gorge that winds for about a mile, to the point where you forget the reputation that precedes it, and suddenly the mighty "Treasury" palace appears before you, carved into the red rock, not disappointing even the wildest of expectations. It sat at the point where the west and east met, a busy market town full of traders and ideas.

Into this melee, I was dropped by my companions, who set off about their own business while I wandered, mouth agape at the wonders of this new world. I must have made quite a figure as I provoked a comment from one market stall owner in a language I could pick out from the cacophony of unfamiliar sounds. It was Greek, and the owner of the voice said simply, "You look lost, my friend."

I looked over. The owner of the voice was a young man about the same age as me, with a full beard, but one that did not conceal a mischievous smile. "I have come a long travel," I answered. "My word, you have come a long way, haven't you? I've heard many men murder the Greek language, but never quite so comprehensively," was the response. "Come, rest your weary legs and let the rest of the world do the walking for a while." "My name is Joseph. I'm not from Petra either, but Arimathea, a long way away in the Kingdom of Judea." My ears pricked up. I had heard of Palestine and the tribe of the Israelites and their obscure cult of worshipping only one god. I was disappointed, however, to hear that it was still a long way away. I hoped Joseph's idea of a long way was not the same as mine after such a long journey.

And so it was that we spent the afternoon together, and the next day and the next, until I started to help out Joseph on his stall, translating for the many eastern traders and travellers we encountered. Joseph found me a small but comfortable house in the east of the town, and often we would meet up in the evenings, sometimes with others, and talk into the small hours about the strange lands and wonders of the world they had seen and their traditions. One night we met, as people often do, by the central fountain of the city, and Joseph opened the conversation by saying, "Your Greek is good enough now. It no longer causes me pain to listen to."

"Thanks," I said.

Joseph continued in a slightly conspiratorial tone, "There is someone I think you should meet. A Greek."

Petra 0 BC

Joseph led the way and surprised me by not turning into the tavern quarter but heading south into the part of Petra I had not hitherto entered. It soon became apparent why. The houses turned from simple brick dwellings to stone, then gradually grew in stature as they progressed up the hill. Finally, after navigating a few last twisting alleys, our destination came into view. The entrance was not much to look at, but it was obvious that behind the wall lay a house of some substance. I took one last glance back down the hill to see that this house had a commanding view of the entire valley in which Petra lay. This was not going to be just any evening.

The owner of the house greeted Joseph at the gate. He was tall and some twenty years older than Joseph and me, with a distinctly patrician manner without being at all unfriendly. "So this is the young man you've been telling me about, Joseph," Philip added. "A Buddhist, no less; quite the novelty around these parts. Welcome, welcome. Welcome to the real wonders of Petra." With that, he ushered us into a reception area larger than the whole of my house and perhaps even that of Joseph. Arranged around the room were stone benches covered with pillows that were clearly from points east and gave me a momentary pang of homesickness. This was the house of someone who liked to entertain, and entertain he did, with the finest wines I had ever tasted and servants bringing in courses of local delicacies too numerous to remember.

And so began a new pattern in my life, starting Monday evenings and then working its way through the week as I gained Philip's attention and trust until we were meeting regularly every Friday night, when Philip was not away tending to his mysterious but seemingly vast trading empire, bringing together all corners of the Hellenic world. After the meal, the debate was always lively, ranging from the curse of the Romans to the farthest reaches of the Indian empire that I could relate, but gradually it turned more and more, as these things do, to religion.

After a particularly sumptuous meal, sometime later, Philip began, "Gentlemen, these long winter months have given me much to think about. The contrast of your relating of the Torah and the teaching of the Buddha has led me to the conclusion that we are at a turning point in history. A unique coming together of ideas that must soon lead to something new in the way man relates to his world." "I can see the old jumble of gods of my old Greek world, one for the harvest, one for prosperity, coming together under the Jew's all-powerful one god. This new idea seems to me so powerful and well adapted to the needs of man, it will sweep all before it."

He continued, "Consider two islands. On one they have 'the law' about how they should behave towards each other, given to them by god. Each week they assemble in a special house of the law to reiterate and celebrate their good fortune to have and live by the law which binds them together as a society. On the other island, there is no written law, and all people live by their own selfish desires for the moment. Which island do you think will prosper? Provided the law is good, which would you rather live on?"

"We have our law. It is written in the Torah, passed down to us by Moses and inscribed in stone on Mount Sinai," said Joseph.

“This is exactly what I am talking about,” said Philip, “but the problem is, if your god is the god of all men, why is this covenant restricted only to the peoples of your tribe? Your god is a jealous god. We need to extend a new covenant to all men.”

“You make it sound like we can choose our gods like we would goods in a bazaar. God will intervene if this is his will.”

“And we cannot? Why would god make us continue to be divided as we have been since your Tower of Babel? Must we wait for a new prophet? What are prophets if not men?”

“You speak dangerous thoughts, Philip. We are not prophets, much less gods, you and I.”

I had been silent to this point, and said, “My lord Buddha was a man, a prince who, through the power of thought and meditation, saved millions from the yoke of suffering. We have our house of the law, though they are not laws but teachings of Lord Buddha, written in scrolls. We revere him like a god, but he was a man that walked the earth like any of us.”

“Not like any of us, we are but traders who have drunk too much wine,” said Joseph, but Philip continued, “Not like us, perhaps, but would it not be possible to nominate and train a new prophet with the best of our traditions from birth and send him out into the world to make of it what he would.”

“But what authority would he have? The world is already full of cults and sects. Why would our new would-be prophet be taken seriously, even if it were not dangerous that he should be?” said Joseph.

“I might have the answer to that,” said Philip. “It is late now. Meet me here tomorrow night. I have something you need to see.”

And with that, Joseph and I took our leave and made our way home. As we parted by the central fountain, Joseph said, “The old man—the power of the grape was strong with him tonight,” and winked. I smiled and turned east to my night’s rest.

The Clock

Joseph and I arrived at Philip's house just after sunset. Instead of the evening's meal laid out in the reception area in the centre of the room, we found a small table and on it a small wooden box with open sides about the size of a shoe box. On the top face of the box were a number of circular brass plates inscribed with symbols that we didn't recognise, with small black extensions called "hands" reaching out from the centre so as to sweep across the various mysterious markings. Looking inside the box, I could see about twenty brass wheels of various sizes, each with teeth around the outside resembling those of a small fish, arranged such that the teeth engaged each other where the wheels met. [Tenzin was looking at an example of what is now known as the "Antikythera mechanism". Discovered in 1900 in the wreck of a Roman galley from the 1st century BC, it seems clear now that this was a very advanced form of celestial clock. Philip goes on to describe it.]

"Gentlemen, you see before you a box containing a form of magic," Philip said as he entered the room with a flourish. "It has been in my family for generations. It was given to me by my father, who maintained it was given to us by the great philosopher Archimedes himself." He stood the box up and inserted a form of key or crank into the side and started to turn it. The black hands began to dance over the faces of the circular plates, and after a few turns we could see they moved at greatly differing speeds, sometimes coming into line with the inscriptions beneath. After a while, Philip stopped turning the crank and said, "There, you see, we are now on the current day," and started to describe the meaning of the various dials. Joseph and I couldn't see anything at first until, after a while, with Philip moving the day forward and back, he explained that the first dial was the movement of the moon and others the movements of the planets through the sky.

"This dial is the most interesting at the moment. For weeks now it has predicted there would be the bright star in the sky that we can see at the moment to the west. My father told me the last time he saw this there was also a comet in the west that lasted some three months, just as the machine predicted. What I want to show you is these two dials on the back," and he started to turn the handle of the machine for a good few minutes until he suddenly stopped. "There." He seemed pleased with himself. Joseph and I exchanged a glance as if we were listening to an eccentric. "We are now at your festival of Passover in thirty-three years' time, Joseph. Look now at the dials." The two hands he indicated were now one over the other. Silence ensued. "If this machine is correct, and it was the last time this happened, the sun will be covered by the moon the afternoon of Passover thirty-three years from now."

Joseph was the first to grasp the meaning of what he had seen, if not quite appreciating the significance of what he said. "With knowledge such as this, a man could become a God." "But how is this possible?" I asked. "Long ago the Greeks learned that the movements of the heavens are like the turning of a wheel on a cart. If we know our past, it is possible to predict our future," answered Philip, and signalled for dinner to be brought in.

Our conversation over dinner was particularly animated. Most troubled was Joseph. "But this is a conjuring trick, you cannot manufacture God," he said. Philip's reply was measured. "Whether god exists or not is not the point. We need to find a way for men to come to him. If we all believe, then in a very real sense god exists. We have formed a relationship with a force for good, if nothing more, and if we follow his/its law we will all be the better for it. The key is the belief, regardless of the reality. Go back to my two islands. One has a "god" and one is without. Where would you choose to live?"

“But where will we find our would-be prophet who will guide people to this belief?” I asked.
“How can we steal a person’s life for the sake of your spiritual experiment?”

“I have been thinking a lot about that,” said Philip. “Quite by chance an opportunity has presented itself. One of my traders has told me of a destitute young couple that has a child on the way for whom the father is not known. In today’s world, only a desperate life lies ahead for the baby, and I propose we adopt the child if we can get the parents’ agreement.”

“I don’t see how we can take a child away from its parents, Philip. Neither of us is ready for parenthood, and for you, perhaps the time has passed,” said Joseph.

“Let’s visit the couple and see if we can come to an arrangement that we sponsor and educate him until he comes of age, and then he is free to do what he pleases.”

And so, all in agreement, the three of us set off, after a week’s preparation, to the west, to Bethlehem in Judea.

Bethlehem 0 BC

For the father of the newborn, the arrival of the three strangers from the east, promising to provide for the baby Jesus, was a godsend. He had no idea how he was going to be able to provide for his wife's new child. His wife, Mary, was less sanguine. *Why are these people here? What do they want with my child in return?* she thought, but she knew they had no alternative, and on the couple's return to Galilee Jesus enjoyed an upbringing more privileged than it would otherwise have been, with the help of these "Three Wise Men". The only difference was that, from time to time, one or other of his three new "uncles" would visit to oversee his education, which, as time progressed, evolved into long walks introducing him to their traditions, conflicts between them, and the aspects they shared.

AD 20 The visit of Philip

Jesus later recounted to me in detail his first experience of Philip in full flow. It was then that he realised Philip had been quietly sponsoring his religious education. Jesus began: "Thank you, Philip, for all you have done for my family, but would it be impolite to ask what you saw in me and what you would want in return?" to which Philip replied, "Only your ear, young man, to introduce you to the traditions of my homeland of Greece, to complete your education and turn you into a man of substance." Jesus was sceptical that he needed to know about the strange ways of such a far-away land, but he had come such a long way, so he let Philip continue.

Philip introduced himself by saying, "Look around you, Jesus, what do you see? What do you think you see?" "I see my father's garden," Jesus replied, perplexed. Philip continued, "I see the distant Mediterranean Sea that brought me here that provides the water nature craves, transported to this parched land by the clouds, that falls as rain. What do you eat, Jesus?" "We bake our own bread," Jesus replied. "When you bake it, do you see the heat of thousands of suns remembered by the wood and returned to you?" Jesus was taken aback, he recounted to me later. He had never heard someone talk in this way. The conversation morphed into a long walk in his father's olive groves under the full moon.

The next day, Philip began what would prove to be an even longer discourse, "No one knows what came before, but we have our own sacred texts that tell the myths of my land. Tales of the gods, the immortals and kings, preserved in the poems of Homer and the histories of Herodotus. One poem, *The Iliad*, read by young Greeks to build character, tells of a campaign to the kingdom of Troy where a warrior, Achilles, reputed to be the son of a god, after an epic siege brought down a great kingdom and his name became immortal. These tales are a jumble of things we accept and things we cannot understand, but they exemplify the qualities it takes to be Greek and give us our identity."

"For much of our history we have fought amongst ourselves in a seemingly never-ending competition between the city-states and their distinct cultures, but eventually my hometown, Athens, became ascendant. There followed a remarkable flowering of thought, and a great experiment was born: that men could govern themselves rather than be ruled by a king, through a new system: democracy. There, except for the slaves, of course, all native citizens were given an equal vote in the polis where decisions were made."

"Women?" Jesus quipped.

"Are you mad?" snapped Philip.

Jesus laughed, though he wasn't sure the joke was all that funny.

Philip pressed on. "Then came the age of the philosophers. Every day, men of means gathered in the town square of Athens and talked, talked, and talked about the issues of the day, nature, and gossiped about the latest scandal, and came to think not just about thought but thinking itself. The greatest of the philosophers was Socrates, who believed one could find any answer by simply asking the right question. Eventually they started schools where the young could be educated with the new ideas, and the conversation became more and more open until suddenly Socrates was charged with 'Corrupting the Youth'."

"Now, I dare say Socrates was no stranger to scandal down at the gymnasium, given his views on marriage, but that's not what he was accused of. They maintained that mere contact with Socrates was permanently damaging the minds of youth, as if there were thoughts that must not be thought. Socrates was given the possibility to nominate his own punishment and suggested he might be exiled to an island, but in the end the democratic polis decided he should take his own life by drinking poison, which he did in good spirits, by all accounts, in the company of his students."

"How could they steal the life of a man for asking questions?" asked Jesus.

"It was a tragic mistake. One that disillusioned his best student, Plato. If this were the result of democracy, he reasoned, he must set about imagining an ideal city, *The Republic*, along with his preposterous 'Noble Lie' of 'The Myth of the Metals', where all people are born Gold, Silver, or Bronze by nature, and the Gold class were born to govern. He was magnanimous in that he conceded a Bronze child could be born of Gold parents, and likewise a Gold child could be born of Bronze parents. The problem was, how do you select this ruling class and, inevitably, when they become corrupt and start governing for themselves and the interests of commerce rather than the whole of society, how do you get rid of them?"

Jesus observed, "Then you're back where you started. How do you choose the right elite next time round?"

"I know, right?" said Philip or something very like it. "At least with democracy, if you elect a clown, you can always toss them out. Plato got one thing right, though. If somehow a Bronze person seized control, it would be the end of his Republic."

"Plato's student Aristotle decided it would be wise to steer away from politics and turned to reflecting on what reason could teach about how an individual should conduct himself in society so that all might 'flourish'. He believed one should practise certain basic 'virtues' including, courage, generosity, and prudence so they become second nature. One could then be said to have developed 'character'.

"So successful was he that the ambitious King of Macedon, also called Philip, hired him to educate his young son. When Philip was brutally assassinated, this son, Alexander, went on the rampage and unified all of Greece by conquest. Perhaps Aristotle had made him read too much Homer and, after his idol Achilles, he forgot to stop campaigning, and his army defeated Darius and the mighty kingdom of Persia. He marched on, without really knowing why, reaching the borders of another great civilisation to the east, on the banks of the Indus, which indirectly brought an interesting young monk, Tenzin, whom you will meet, to my table in Petra."

"In each conquered country he left behind some of his best generals to administer the country, and Greece had its own empire, 'the Hellenic civilisation', stretching from Macedonia in the north to the sullen land of Egypt, another great civilisation older than time itself on the banks of the mighty River Nile."

"In the meantime, the mysterious Etruscan people of the tree-lined valleys between the three volcanoes north of Rome came down and founded their city on the seven hills. They even had their own origin story, something about a wolf and two brothers, Romulus and Remus. With time, their traders brought the works of our philosophers to them, and they organised themselves as a republic after Plato, only this time with an intermediate

democratic body, the Senate. There, good types could discuss and vote on affairs of state. The members of the Senate were taken from what they called the equestrian order—that is, those who could afford horses.”

“But Rome was ambitious and could countenance no threat, and soon they chopped down all their trees, built ships, and set about to ‘pacify’ all nations around the Mediterranean. ‘Our Lake’, they called it. It took them a hundred years, but eventually they defeated their last imagined mortal enemy, Carthage.”

“Finally Rome’s attention turned to Greece, and as we were divided amongst ourselves, as ever, we were vanquished. They stole our gods, copied our fine arts and architecture, and had our best philosophers teach in their schools in Rome. Our entire culture was handed to them on a plate. Who was the vanquished wasn’t entirely clear.”

“We’re brothers, though, the Romans and the Greeks, and to talk to a Roman is to talk to the Greek in his heart. They may seem severe in your homeland, but empire is a serious business, and your countrymen are a rowdy bunch, made giddy by the knowledge that they are the chosen people of their one all-powerful God. No empire is immortal, though, Jesus; it’s ideas that endure. Even Rome knows that.”

“Then the next of the great warriors I will recount to you, Julius Caesar, was too successful in his conquests of distant Gaul and tried to have himself appointed not just as King but Emperor, since Rome was now an empire. His friends turned on him, and he was assassinated on the steps of their Senate by smaller men who claimed they were defending the Republic from tyranny.”

“It fell to his adopted son Octavian, who governed as ‘Augustus’, to disassemble the remnants of the Republic, and we were back where we started, with a dynasty of leaders chosen by adoption if you were fortunate or in the bedchamber. As the quality of men tends to increase with the generations of the great families, as does their wealth, I suppose it’s not the worst arbitrary system to select leaders.”

Jesus’ head was spinning. “This is all very interesting to know, Philip, but if you loved the beautiful things Athens achieved so much, how could you leave it to live in Petra?”

“It is true, Jesus. Athens had its golden age where everything seemed possible, but that is long past now. Greece was like a family back then. We quarrelled like any family, but every year, war or no war, we met at Olympia for games where we handed out laurels to our finest athletes. It’s all much more sordid now. Petra, on the other hand, is a great crucible of ideas at the end of the trading routes that lead to the east. Traders are the journeymen, bringing with them not just goods but new ideas, new worlds, new faiths. It’s a cosmopolitan place where nothing must not be said or thought, and one is free to talk and argue about all things with people from all parts of the world.”

“As you travel through life, Jesus, in such a place you collect ideas like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle until sometimes the pieces lock together and you get a coherent view of the tides of cause and effect that shape the world in which we all live.”

By now Jesus was getting tired. “How do you know so many things, Philip?”

“I read all the dispatches and books my traders bring to me, and I’m very careful who I listen to. You could be a journeyman too, Jesus, if you wanted to. I can’t promise you’ll

collect all the pieces or even that you'll be able to find a way for them to fit together, but I sense you hunger to try, and I'm proud of you for that. No man can know his destiny in life, Jesus, and perhaps I only found my own in talking with you now."

"But how can I be a journeyman, Philip? I do not travel, and I need to make my own bed each day and find food for the table like any other."

"Live modestly, Jesus, it's not what you earn that makes you rich but what you spend. You have your trade to support you, and you should always know you have your adopted uncles if you ever need support. The beauty of ideas is that they can come to you and you can create your own."

They talked on, and Philip regaled Jesus with many other stories, including that of another warrior, Hannibal, who outflanked Rome by bringing elephants through Spain and over the mountains, who was for a time very successful, decisively defeating them on their own peninsula until he was called back to his homeland to defend it. Then there was the story of Mark Antony, who seduced the Egyptian Queen Cleopatra but was in turn seduced by her ambition, as was Rome by the charms of Greece. He also outlined his "two islands" thought experiment, to which Jesus fired back, "What if there is a third island with its own faith? What happens when they come into contact?" Jesus realised for the first time that the more you knew, the more you wanted to know, and he found he liked that feeling.

AD 21 The visit of Tenzin

Jesus started: "My mind is feverish with the stories Philip has told me of there being many gods, men who become gods, women who are gods, men who are not gods but immortal, and, and, elephants!"

I replied, "Yes, Philip is stimulating company, but you must never fear your mind, Jesus. Sometimes, when we become lost in meditation, we say or do things that cause those who love us to become concerned. The mind always recovers, but you will not be the same as you were before; you will have digested some new truth."

"Words are all we have to bind our spirits together, and we must always choose them carefully, doubly so when we write things down. We must never use them to deceive or hurt, and we must never use them to dominate or oppress. Sometimes we may say something hurtful or wrong but, if it is an accident, and we admit our mistake, you're absolved. No man and no act is perfect, Jesus."

"One cannot say all things to all people, and sometimes one must moderate what we say for what the listener is prepared to hear. But I digress. Philip has asked me to come here and tell you the story of my Lord Buddha and what he believed. Would you like to hear that? Let's eat first, and we can make a start."

After dinner I began, "Mine is an ancient civilisation, Jesus, and we had already arrived at our gods, spirituality, and sacred texts while people in Greece were still tending their farms."

"Into this world was born a young prince who became dismayed at the prevalence of suffering in the world. So dismayed was he that, after his studies were complete, he sat down under a fig tree and resolved never to move again until he had found a solution. By the next morning he had become the "Awakened One" and began teaching that suffering was a result of excessive attachment to things and, through meditation, it was possible to find peace and reduce suffering."

"He then started travelling to teach what he had learned far and wide and became, as Philip would put it, "immortal". His teaching even reached another great empire unimaginably far away from where the fine silks that Philip sells in his market come."

"Was he a god?" asked Jesus.

I replied, "He said not, though many have revered him as if he were. He said simply he didn't think that would reduce suffering."

I continued, "Sometimes, when one becomes enlightened, one can appear too content, people can come to resent you. When one is seen as different, resentment can give way to fear in those so attached to worldly things that they feel your ideas may threaten them. Such people may even subject you to ridicule, which one must endure in good spirits. Always treat all people with respect, though, Jesus. Everyone has their own journey to make. If you are to avoid these failings, remember always to keep your own ego in check. Narcissism ruins everything. It makes people detest you and, worse still, destroys your judgment."

“Narcissism?” asked Jesus.

I replied, “It’s one of Philip’s stories about a Greek called Narcissus who fell in love with his own reflection in a lake. Sometimes, to communicate a concept, it is best to tell a story.”

“I understand,” replied Jesus. “I’ve seen some people take too much ostentatious certainty from their faith, and that can make them intolerant and cruel.”

“I am sure there are good people in your tradition, Jesus,” I said. “Don’t give up on faith.”

Jesus thought for a while in silence, “Cannot the striving for individual perfection become a form of conceit? And, what about the people who tend the fields and build the roads or care for their families? Not everybody has the luxury to undertake such a long internal journey.”

I replied, “In my country we have temples. Not to gods, but containing monks familiar with my lord’s teachings, who dispense advice and lead meditation as a service to the community in which they live. In return they walk the streets each morning with a bowl, asking for donations of rice to sustain them.”

We talked on, and I taught Jesus some basic meditation techniques, explained the Buddha’s teaching in more detail, including the “Four Noble Truths”, “Noble Eightfold Path”, “Not Self”, Karma, Rebirth, and the impermanence of life.

Sometimes it seems like I am incapable of speaking without giving advice, and when I met Jesus the next morning I said, “Look after your body on which your mind rests and cultivate good friends with whom you can enjoy life to the full and turn to if all does not go as you wish. Drinking is like laughter. Both can be explosive expressions of solidarity, but are best not enjoyed on your own.”

Jesus said, “Thank you, Tenzin, I’m sure that’s good advice anyone would appreciate.”

To which I had to say, “No need to be harsh, Jesus. Do I have so little to teach you?”

Jesus was taken aback. “I apologise, Tenzin. You have taught me more than you know: how to take full possession of my mind and protect it from others. In the life of the Buddha you’ve also given me a model for a role a man can play in life: to not just accept things but change things that need to be changed and still have the prospect of seeing old age.”

AD 22 The visit of Joseph

Joseph visited Jesus when he had some business in the town. He was by then an intimidating man, though not at all severe. Jesus began, "Thank you, Joseph, you bring honour to my house with your visit. You are a learned man of faith, but with all Philip and Tenzin have taught me my mind has wandered far from the teachings of our church, and I am fearful God will judge me."

Joseph replied, "God will understand, Jesus, if your intentions are honest."

"We all study the sacred scriptures of our faith, which were once the living history of our people, but by designating them the literal word of God it seems to me as if we have killed them. The world changes, and what if it comes time to write another chapter? Who would dare try to write it?"

Joseph replied measuredly, "You confuse insight with ambition, Jesus. The Torah is the word of God, but ours is an old religion and, while I am a member of the Temple, I confess I sometimes let myself question the piety of its institutions. They have turned the Temple in Jerusalem into a market, for example."

Jesus then ventured, "And what of our prophets, Joseph? Does one have to be dead to become a prophet? Were our prophets not once men like us? One has to admire the unique genius of Moses, though, to bring down the Ten Commandments from Mount Sinai and then propose that if we would just follow this simple code we would establish a covenant and become God's chosen people, which has defined our whole nation."

Joseph was resolute. "The commandments Moses brought down from Mount Sinai were the word of God, Jesus. The inspiration was His."

Then Jesus could not help himself. "Sometimes I fear ours is a vengeful God, Joseph. Sometimes it feels as if God's message became 'Do these things or else'. Is there not room for more compassion for all the poverty and suffering in the world, or the failings of men? Sometimes it feels as if those most certain of God's judgement almost take pleasure in the misfortune of others. And what of the Gentiles who are not of our faith? Why is it we cannot share our God with them?"

Joseph's mood darkened. "Do not speak for God, Jesus. If you feel it has come time for you to make a break from your faith, that is your prerogative, but you would have to start that journey on your own and can't expect your faith to come with you. But above all be careful, Jesus. Remember, God is always watching. You will only have one chance to get it right, and if you do not, the consequences for you and those drawn to you will be grave and eternal."

Jesus continued, undeterred, "I just want to teach, Joseph, but I don't want to be the village madman preaching to an empty town square, and nor do I want to suffer the fate of Socrates."

"Who?" said Joseph, and Jesus realised neither Joseph nor their faith had all the pieces and his journey would need to continue. Nonetheless, they continued talking about the prophets, scripture and the scribes, and of course the Romans, into the night until the oil in their lamps ran out.

They met the next morning as Joseph loaded his camels with the goods he was to take back to Jerusalem, and Jesus asked, "Do you think the Messiah will come as is prophesied in our sacred texts?"

Jesus thought he saw Joseph's face change, and he realised he had shocked him. As he turned to leave, Joseph said only, "If it is God's will."

AD 24 The second visit of Philip

It was on the second visit by Philip that Jesus noticed he looked unwell and somehow preoccupied. He was now a very old man, with only a few grey wisps of hair protecting his head from the harsh Galilean sun. When they had greeted with an embrace, Philip had winced with pain.

"What troubles you, brother?" Jesus asked.

"It is nothing," Philip said.

But Jesus knew this not to be true. Philip pressed on, saying, "It has come time for me to complete your education," with a finality that reinforced Jesus' belief that this trip was not to be like the others. "This trip I have something precious to show you. But first, let's eat. It's been a long trip, and we have much to discuss."

After the meal, the atmosphere had almost returned to normal. Philip was still the avid dreamer of old, and there was much to discuss about the affairs in Petra and, as ever, the Romans. At the conclusion of the meal, Philip reached over to one of his pack bags and drew out a small, carefully wrapped package, from which he drew a small wooden box with open sides containing a myriad of brass wheels, and proceeded to show him how it followed the path of the sun, moon, and planets through the sky. Jesus was amused at first, but when Philip wound time forward and revealed the date of the future solar eclipse, only silence followed.

After some time, Jesus asked, "Why do you show me this, Philip?" but he wondered if he already knew the answer. "Would you wish me to use this to start your new church of the islands you have taught me about all these years?"

"I have listened to your reasons why the world should take the next step with good humour, but you forget above all I have been raised a Jew by my parents, already believe in our all-powerful one God, and this is heresy. A man cannot create belief."

Philip was pained. All his work and thought over the years to create the perfect candidate prophet could be for nothing. But he had prepared the answer.

"Can you not say it is possible your God has sent me to you in order to perform His work? Could this not be His plan for the world? A world free of the corrupt old religions, a new religion centred around man for the good of all people, not the priests and the wealth of the temple?"

Jesus paused and could not help but become angry.

"And what of me? What of my life and my family? Do you think the priests will accept this? And what of God? His judgement will be fearsome."

"Go, old man, you are not welcome here anymore. You play with my life like a child would a doll. I've had enough of your meddling in my affairs."

"But Jesus," was all Philip could summon by way of defence, and then, "I'm sorry, perhaps I have been wrong," and he retired a broken man. He left Nazareth and Jesus' world the

next morning without another word being spoken between the two. Jesus later learned that Philip never made it back to Petra. This one last trip had taken his last reserves of energy, and he expired by the side of the road, and his precious box, full of promise, was lost to history.

The last trip was not in vain, though. That he had parted on such bad terms with Philip played upon him, and Jesus realised he had somehow been caught in the destiny that was now no longer his own but that of something greater. Perhaps it was as Philip had said. It was God's plan that he should take all he had learned, and it was required of him to act.

He retired to the desert to meditate. The desert is a magical place where, if you don't mind absolute silence, after a couple of days the hunger passes. The lack of food in your belly unlocks the full power of the mind, normally reserved for when finding food is an imperative.

Forty days is a long time to spend in one's own company, and if you do not go mad and lose your mind completely, it will distil your soul. It was to be Jesus' fig tree. When he came out forty days later, he had reconciled the teachings of his three mentors into something that was uniquely his own. He was fearful of the possible consequences of that fusion, but he steeled himself with another maxim that Philip had taught him: 'Uncertainty is the price of freedom.'

Joseph and I came to hear his "Sermon on the Mount". At the end, the normally staid Joseph was beaming from ear to ear, repeating, "It's him, it's him, it's him." Then, "He's the one. My God, he walks here amongst us. Whatever is going to happen now?"

And well he may have asked. Over the next two short years of Jesus' ministry, I have it on good authority from people I respect who were there, there were things that happened that simply cannot be explained. Had his God given him special powers, or was he always the chosen one and it was his God who guided Philip, Joseph, and me to witness his birth?

The rest of his story is well known. It was related to me by Jesus and Joseph when he summoned me to Jerusalem.

Palestine AD 33

On a well-trodden trail on a barren hillside, a small group of a dozen or so weary travellers made their way through an afternoon dust storm that was beginning to gather. Just behind the main party, two stragglers lagged behind by a hundred metres and seemed to be in deep debate, oblivious to the others and the need to find shelter before long. To look at them, you wouldn't have picked a more unlikely pair. One, tall, tanned, and athletic, walked with a gentle, confident gait, while the other, thin and wiry, gesticulated wildly as he spoke:

"This is madness, Jesus. Is there nothing I can say to deter you from this path? Only trouble awaits you in Jerusalem."

His tall companion answered, "You, more than anybody, Judas, understand why we have taken this path, even if it leads to Jerusalem, and what we know waits for me there. My life is no longer my own, and indeed perhaps it never was mine to live. We must continue to follow this course regardless of where it leads."

"But it is your very life that is at stake, Jesus. You needn't throw it away. Turn back now to Galilee, and let us continue your work amongst your people."

"I am decided," said Jesus in a matter-of-fact way that betrayed no emotion.

"You've fallen under the influence of that eastern mystic and his friends from Petra. They fill your mind with their ideas of immortality, a life outside your life, when the life you need to live is here amongst us."

"I am decided, and time is short. Passover is but a week away, and there is much to do," said Jesus as they rounded the crest of the hill and their destination came into view.

Before entering Jerusalem, Jesus stopped to arrange that he be able to ride into Jerusalem on a donkey and to do so through the East Gate. This he did to the wild acclaim of those who had gathered to greet him. A more provocative act is difficult to imagine, it being in the scriptures that the "Messiah" would arrive on a donkey through the East Gate. Thus, Jesus, initiated the course of events that would lead to his crucifixion before the end of that week.

Gethsemane

Jesus and his party had retired to Gethsemane, at the full moon, just outside the city walls, for supper under the cool of the ancient olive trees. It had been an eventful couple of days since his arrival. His reputation as a healer and preacher around Galilee in the years before had preceded him, and everywhere he went crowds flocked to him, some nearly hysterical and some just curious about this new troublemaker. He had certainly attracted the attention of the established priesthood, not least of the local administration, fearful of disorder in the always volatile town.

And yet, "Still they do not act," said Jesus to Judas as they walked some distance from the main group. "And Passover is but two days away."

"The crowd protects you, Jesus," said Judas. "They do not want to create a confrontation."

Jesus thought a while and said, "If that is so, I need you to make it easy for them. There is no crowd now. Go to the authorities and tell them of my location."

"Are you sure, Jesus? This is your last chance to escape back to obscurity by the sea. If you are here when I return, they will not show any pity."

Jesus replied, "They must not show pity. It has to come to its inevitable end on Passover. Otherwise, my ministry will all have been for nothing."

With that, the two embraced and Judas left. Jesus returned to the group under the olives.

His mother had been watching and said simply, "What have you done, Jesus? I knew I never should have accepted the help of Philip and his friends when you were born. He was always the dreamer."

"So you knew him before my birth?" Jesus said.

But the answer was obvious now he looked back, and again Jesus felt the pain of their last meeting.

"He would be proud of everything you have achieved, Jesus, these last few years. But I'm sure he never intended you would take this path."

"It is the only path available now, Mother, with what was left for me to finish."

"Are you sure, Jesus? Is there no other way?"

Jesus tried to take comfort from Mary Magdalene, who had been his rock until now, but they had argued. She could never understand why he chose to take the weight of the world on his shoulders, and she too sensed that this weight was becoming unbearable. So Jesus found himself alone in the garden with his thoughts. After Philip's death, when he retired to the desert to think through what his final revelation had meant in practice, it had become clear to him his life had always been on a collision course with the world the way it was. There was no way his own religion could accept what was to come, and there was no place on earth for prophets and gods. Was there no other way?

Just then he was gripped by the desire to run away, to escape with Mary and lead the simple life due to any good man. Why should he take this road? What if he was wrong in his conclusions? Must he pay with his life to bring to pass Philip's new covenant for all

men? Why should he be the vessel through which people can find a new relationship with God? Would his acts even have any impact at all on the selfishness of the world? How had he reached this point? Why was there seemingly no other way?

He was just at the point of running to Mary to tell her he had been wrong all along when he heard the distant jangle of Roman armour. It was too late. The die was cast. What was to come was now as inevitable as it had been since before he was born.

Pilate

Just north of Rome lie three small, long-extinct volcanoes. The land of the Etruscans. On the side of the middle and smallest of the three you will find a town, reputed to be the childhood home of Pontius Pilate. I mention this as he too has a back-story other than that of the comic-book villain which he is so commonly portrayed as by the Christians. Once he was a child, fishing in the lake that now fills the caldera or walking under the speckled shade of the beech trees at its side, as you can today. This was all before he was sent down to the senatorial schools for his education in the ways of the state. He had been a good student and rose rapidly through the ranks of the administration.

One day, he was summoned to an audience before Emperor Tiberius at his island palace of Capri. "You have come to my attention as one of our most promising young administrators," the emperor started. "Our troublesome province of Judea has need of a person of your exceptional powers of tact and persuasion."

Pilate's heart sank.

"This will not be an easy assignment; the Judeans have beliefs which compel them to extreme acts of insurrection, but I'm sure you know how to take a firm hand."

"As you wish," was the only answer Pilate could give as Tiberius turned back to more pressing affairs of state in the next room.

The emperor's words rang in his ears as Pilate surveyed the scene in front of him. His council chamber was full of a mob baying for the execution of the man before him, stripped to the waist and whom the palace guards had obviously let vent to their renowned brutality. Standing like a Cheshire cat to one side was the high priest of the temple, who had brought the unfortunate individual before him, claiming he was a threat to the state.

"More likely a threat to their church," Pilate thought to himself.

Pilate had made his own inquiries and found him to be something else. Something far more powerful, someone preaching a more direct connection to this troublesome one god of the Jews, a relationship with a greater allegiance than that to the state, and while he had not shown any aggression towards Rome, such an idea was a dangerous one. Pilate's role was also to keep the peace, which this man had certainly not done since his arrival in Jerusalem. Something would have to be done.

Pilate began, "Jesus, you have your beliefs, but for me they are too extreme. I too believe in the gods and pay them due respect. But they form only a part of our destiny. Your ideas would break a delicate balance that has taken centuries to establish. What gives a madman more reason to do a terrible wrong than his belief that it is a god's will?"

"If it is God's will, then it must be done," Jesus replied.

"God is not here with us always. What if your church became corrupted?"

"A man would know what is God's will in his heart."

"Would you obey Him above the Emperor?"

"I have no choice but to obey Him," Jesus said.

"There, you see!" the high priest interrupted. "This man must be crucified. You have no choice under the law."

"Can't you see that by executing this man you will increase his stature, not diminish it?" said Pilate.

But there was no assuaging him or the mob.

Pilate continued, "This man has chosen to provoke you. Must you rise to it, as is his intention? Ignore him and he will pass into obscurity."

"That does not affect how you must act, Pilate," the high priest said. "You must apply your laws and ours and crucify him."

Pilate knew this to be the case. While he had some sympathy for the man, it ran against all that Rome stood for that a man's allegiance to his personal idea of God should exceed that due to the state. If anything, Philip's idea was a little too powerful and would at times place in the hands of the church power which it was not qualified to wield. Perhaps Pilate foresaw this, but in the event he had no choice according to the law of Rome. The state was not to be challenged.

The Crucifixion

When you think about it, crucifixion is the most extraordinary form of barbarity known to man, without any near exception. It seems to be another thing our story has to thank Alexander for when he brought it back from the east, perhaps from Persia, at the end of his campaigns. A man is nailed to a cross of wood or a tree by his hands and feet and left to hang unsupported until dead.

Gradually, the strength of his lower body and legs fails until he is suffocated by his own weight pulling down slowly on his chest so he cannot breathe, a process that takes surprisingly long—generally three days—during which the most unimaginable pain and a sensation close to drowning must be endured. The only respite from this was if a centurion took pity, broke your legs so you could not support your body and expedited the process. The Christian account of Jesus' crucifixion is well known in their Gospels:

Mark 15:22

And they bring him unto the place Golgotha, which is, being interpreted, The place of a skull.

And they gave him to drink wine mingled with myrrh: but he received it not.

And when they had crucified him, they parted his garments, casting lots upon them, what every man should take.

And it was the third hour, and they crucified him.

And the superscription of his accusation was written over, THE KING OF THE JEWS.

And with him they crucify two thieves; the one on his right hand, and the other on his left.

And the scripture was fulfilled, which saith, And he was numbered with the transgressors.

And they that passed by railed on him, wagging their heads, and saying, Ah, thou that destroyest the temple, and buildest it in three days,

Save thyself, and come down from the cross.

Likewise also the chief priests mocking said among themselves with the scribes, He saved others; himself he cannot save.

Let Christ the King of Israel descend now from the cross, that we may see and believe. And they that were crucified with him reviled him.

And when the sixth hour was come, there was darkness over the whole land until the ninth hour.

And at the ninth hour Jesus cried with a loud voice, saying, Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani? which is, being interpreted, My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

And some of them that stood by, when they heard it, said, Behold, he calleth Elias.

And one ran and filled a sponge full of vinegar, and put it on a reed, and gave him to drink, saying, Let alone; let us see whether Elias will come to take him down.

And Jesus cried with a loud voice, and gave up the ghost.

And the veil of the temple was rent in twain from the top to the bottom.

And when the centurion, which stood over against him, saw that he so cried out, and gave up the ghost, he said, Truly this man was the Son of God.

There were also women looking on afar off: among whom was Mary Magdalene, and Mary the mother of James the less and of Joses, and Salome;

(Who also, when he was in Galilee, followed him, and ministered unto him;) and many other women which came up with him unto Jerusalem.

And now when the even was come, because it was the preparation, that is, the day before the sabbath,

Joseph of Arimathaea, an honourable counsellor, which also waited for the kingdom of God, came, and went in boldly unto Pilate, and craved the body of Jesus.

And Pilate marvelled if he were already dead: and calling unto him the centurion, he asked him whether he had been any while dead.

And when he knew it of the centurion, he gave the body to Joseph.

And he bought fine linen, and took him down, and wrapped him in the linen, and laid him in a sepulchre which was hewn out of a rock, and rolled a stone unto the door of the sepulchre.

And Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Joses beheld where he was laid.

[I think I can guess where Joseph “acquired” his “fine cloth”?]

But three days had not yet passed.

Jesus awoke. Were it not for the excruciating pain that wracked his body from head to toe, he would have assumed he was dead. He looked around, but all he could see was an impenetrable darkness accompanied by a cold that only added to his discomfort. All he could remember was the sun going dark, as Philip had prophesied, and pain. After some hours trying to gauge where he was and what had happened to him to leave him in such a place, his senses were drawn to a muffled scratching, scraping sound. Then, suddenly, all around was saturated with a blinding light. He was dead after all, he thought, and prepared to make his account to God. In the light, a shadow appeared, and he heard a familiar voice. It was Joseph of Arimathea, his mentor from all those years, who said with some urgency, "We really need to get you away from here."

It took Jesus some days to digest what had happened to him and months for his body to recover from its ordeal at the cross. At first he was angry with Joseph. "You've ruined everything I've set out to achieve with my ministry these last two years. I had to die and be reborn so men who led modest lives could learn not to fear death."

Joseph replied, "Reborn, Jesus? How would that be possible? It may be part of Tenzin's religion, but it is not part of mine. Would you have me believe I am talking to God here, now?"

"Tenzin believes when one reaches nirvana you do not die, but your spirit passes into another dimension for eternity."

Joseph measured his response. "With respect, Jesus, that's a distinction that may come to be misunderstood. The trouble is, a person does not know what one does not know. We must all come to our own terms with death sooner or later; God makes it much easier when one has led a decent life."

Jesus thought for a while. "Do you think that's a danger, Joseph—that people will simplify my teachings, become too attached, and do terrible things?"

"Was it not enough they crucified you? Sacrifice need not arrive at martyrdom. I suspect even Pilate found sympathy for your teachings when I presented him with the opportunity. If it's any consolation, your disappearance from the tomb was your final miracle. It's all people talk about in the town now, and I believe you have become one of Philip's immortals. Right now we need to get you away from here. Gods do not walk amongst men. It only leads to envy."

"You see, as the date of the eclipse determined you must be crucified exactly on Passover AD33, it also opened the possibility that you might be taken down a day early for "the preparation" for the Sabbath, and somehow you survived. The irony is Philip, who started all this, misread his clock, and it was a lunar eclipse that turned the sky red the evening of your crucifixion, not a solar one. The Greek astronomers tell me a solar eclipse is impossible on our Passover, as it is the feast of the full moon."

Jesus stayed at Joseph's house just outside Jerusalem until another familiar face from his past arrived, whom he had not seen in some years: it was I, Tenzin, bringing with me a full camel train for the journey ahead. "There is no place for you here now, Jesus," I said. "We must take you far away to a place where they have never heard of Jews and Romans or your one god."

"I must see Mary," Jesus said again and again as preparations were made for the trip. In the end, Joseph and I relented and took Jesus to a hill where Mary Magdalene was planting the crop for the new season. As they came together and Jesus touched her face, he finally realised that he was still alive.

Two years later, a small camel train made their way along a barren mountain pass in Ladakh. As we reached the crest of the hill, I saw the mighty white tooth of the Great Father come into view and stopped to let the rest of the party catch up. It had been half a life since I had stood on this spot.

"This is to be my new life?" Jesus asked as he reached the crest and surveyed the broad valley spread out below him.

Jesus looked back and called out to the final member of the party. "We've arrived, Mary, just as well as you really shouldn't be travelling in your condition."

I am Tenzin. These are real memories for me mixed with the unreal memories of an old man, and still, I cannot understand why it should be me that witnessed them. Even after 20 years there is still much I cannot explain: how a young man became something more than Philip could ever have imagined. Men have argued as to whether Jesus was divine or even the Son of God himself. On these matters I have been unable to reach a conclusion.

This distinction does not trouble me as much as it once did, for I realised you needn't decide one way or the other. If he were God, that would explain the things that happened, but if he were not, then that makes his story all the more remarkable. Is it enough that, if we all believe or instinctively follow his code as second nature, then God must exist, as Philip said?

Jesus is here with me now as I write this, and I sometimes wonder if even he fully appreciates what he will become.

